



EAT THE WOODS

How to Find the Best Foraging
Spots in the Adirondacks
& How to Prepare Them
Stranded With Nothing

by Rook

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Read this first (it's short, and it might save your life)

This guide is blunt, not botanical. I'm not a botanist, and these pages are not an identification manual -- **do not identify plants from the illustrations in this book**. They're linocut art, not field photos. Before you eat anything wild, confirm it against a real field guide with color photographs (Peterson's *Field Guide to Edible Wild Plants* is the standard), and if you can, learn your first plants from a person who already knows them. A local foraging walk is worth a hundred pages.

The rule that overrides everything in here: **if you cannot positively identify it, you do not eat it**. "Pretty sure" has killed people who knew more than you.

Also: foraging laws vary. State parks, private land, and city land all have their own rules. Don't trespass, don't strip a patch bare, and don't forage next to roads, sprayed fields, or industrial ground -- plants take up lead, pesticides, and runoff from contaminated soil, so don't gamble on the location.

Numbers and seasons below are for the Northeast US and Appalachia, current as of fall 2026.

0. The rules (read or die)

1. **Positive ID or nothing.** Every plant you eat, you name first -- common name and the key features, out loud, like you mean it. 2. **Learn the killers before the edibles.** Section 4. Memorize them the way you'd memorize the face of someone who owes you money. 3. **When in doubt, throw it out.** There is no prize for bravery. The woods will still be there tomorrow. 4. **Take less than a tenth of any patch.** Never take the only plant. You're a guest. 5. **The universal edibility test does not work on mushrooms.** Nothing in Section 5 applies to fungi. Ever. 6. **Allergies are real.** Try any new wild food in a small amount first, then wait a day.



1. Stranded with nothing: the order of operations

So you're lost in the woods with nothing but your pecker and a hope. Here's the thing most people get backwards: **food is the last thing you worry about.** Your body can go three weeks without food. It cannot go three hours without shelter in bad cold, or three days without water. That's the Rule of Threes -- a mnemonic for *priorities*, not a stopwatch. Real survival times vary wildly with conditions, clothing, and health, but the order is the whole game:

- **3 minutes** without air - **3 hours** without shelter (in extreme heat or cold) - **3 days** without water - **3 weeks** without food

So you work the list in order. The killer closest to *now* gets handled first.

STOP

The second you realize you're lost: **Sit. Think. Observe. Plan.** Panic is what gets people killed -- it makes people walk in circles

until dark and then die of exposure a mile from the trail. Sit down. Drink some water if you have it. Think about what you know: last known position, which way is downhill (streams run downhill; people usually do too -- usually), what the weather's doing. *Then* act.

Tell people before you go (the free life insurance)

Almost every search-and-rescue failure starts the same way: nobody knew the person was missing. Before you go into the woods, tell someone where you're going and when you'll be back. Costs nothing. This one habit does more than every skill in this chapter combined -- because the best survival strategy is **stay put and let them find you**.

Priority 1: Shelter

Exposure kills faster than hunger ever will. In the Northeast, even summer nights can drop into the 50s, and wet + wind will strip your body heat fast.

The debris hut -- the shelter you can build with literally nothing:

1. Find a long, sturdy ridgepole -- a fallen branch about 9 feet long, one end propped on a stump, rock, or forked tree at hip height, the other end on the ground. 2. Lean ribs (sticks) against both sides of the ridgepole, close together, like a little A-frame tent. 3. Pile debris -- leaves, pine needles, ferns, bark -- over the whole thing **at least 2 feet thick**. This is the part everyone underdoes. Two feet. It will compress. 4. Crawl in feet-first. Stuff the inside with dry leaves around your body like a sleeping bag. Plug the entrance with a bundle of debris behind you.

Site selection: high enough that water drains away from you (never in a gully or dry creek bed), out of the wind if you can manage it, and look up -- **no dead branches overhead** ("widowmakers"). One falling limb undoes everything.

Priority 2: Water

Downhill. Water flows down, so you walk down -- valleys, green vegetation, animal tracks converging, the sound of it. Morning dew can be sopped up with a cloth and wrung into your mouth. A clear plastic bag tied over a leafy branch (transpiration bag) *may* collect some water by afternoon -- treat it as a supplement, not a plan. Never bag a plant you haven't positively identified as non-toxic.

Never drink it straight. Clear mountain water is full of things you

can't see -- giardia will have you shitting yourself dehydrated within one to three weeks, which is a fast way to die when you're already in trouble.

- **Best:** boil it. Rolling boil, one minute (three minutes above 6,500 feet -- which is nowhere in the Northeast, so one minute does it here). No pot? Hot-rock boiling: heat rocks in your fire (not river rocks -- trapped water can make them explode), drop them into water held in a bark container, a hollowed log, or even a sturdy leaf cup. Keep cycling hot rocks until it boils. - **Good:** filter through layers of cloth, then charcoal from your fire, then sand -- then still boil it if you can. - **Okay in a pinch:** SODIS -- *clear* water in a *clear, colorless plastic* bottle, full sun, 6 hours minimum. If it's cloudy, give it two full days. Doesn't touch chemicals -- and it's a distant third behind boiling.

Priority 3: Fire

Fire is warmth, boiled water, cooked food, a signal, and -- underrated -- morale. A fire at night is the difference between a person surviving and a person giving up.

With nothing, you're making friction fire, and I'll be straight with you: **this is a skill you practice in your backyard before you need it in the woods.** Reading about the bow drill and doing the bow drill are different planets.

The bow drill in brief: a bow (curved stick + cordage -- shoelace, paracord, strip of bark), a spindle (straight dry softwood stick, ~8 inches), a hearth board (flat dry softwood -- cedar, willow, cottonwood, basswood), and a bearing block (hardwood or stone to hold the top of the spindle). Saw the spindle into the board with the bow until you get a coal, drop the coal into a tinder bundle (dry bark fibers, cattail fluff, bird's nest of fine grasses), and blow it to flame.

Wood matters: both spindle and board should be **dry, dead, softwood**. Your tinder bundle should be bone-dry and fine as hair. One damp component and you're sawing for nothing.

Fire lays: start teepee (airflow for ignition), graduate to log cabin or lean-to once it's going. Feed it gradually -- smothering a young fire with a log is a classic.

Priority 4: Signal

Three blasts, three fires, three flashes -- the rule of threes is the widely taught distress pattern. Make it rhythmic and deliberate so it

reads as a signal, not noise. If you have a whistle, it carries farther than your voice and doesn't wear out your throat.

Stay put if someone knows where you are. Self-rescue -- walking out -- is how lost people become dead people, unless you're certain of the route or certain nobody's coming.

Priority 5: Food (last, and that's the point)

Here's the math nobody wants to hear: you will burn 300-500 calories stumbling around gathering a handful of berries worth 50. In the first days, **foraging is something you do passively while handling shelter, water, and fire** -- nibbling dandelion leaves you recognize on the way to water, not mounting an expedition.

Passive calories beat active hunting: a fish trap in a stream works while you sleep. A snare works while you build shelter. Your own two legs chasing rabbits is a net loss. **Know the law first:** snares and fish traps are illegal or tightly regulated in many states -- snares are flatly illegal in New York, for example. Check your state's current law before you ever set one. "Survival" is not a blanket defense outside a genuine emergency, and a poaching fine is a bad souvenir.

Once shelter, water, fire, and signal are handled -- *then* you forage in earnest, and that's what the rest of this book is for.

The part nobody writes down

Boredom and despair are real threats. People give up. So: keep a routine. Tend the fire. Improve the shelter. Whittle something. Talk out loud -- narrate what you're doing like you're teaching someone. It sounds insane and it works. You are your own company now; be good company.



2. The 10 safest beginner plants (no deadly lookalikes)

Learn these first. None of them has a lookalike that will kill you as *long as you run the checks given* -- which is exactly why they're first. For each one: learn it in your yard or a park *before* you need it in the woods.

Dandelion -- *Taraxacum officinale*. Every part: young leaves (salads, or cooked to cut the bitterness), flowers (fritters), roots roasted for a coffee substitute. Spring leaves are mildest; roots best in fall. Grows everywhere humans have been. The minor lookalikes (cat's ear, sow thistle) are also edible -- this plant barely lets you go wrong.

Chickweed -- *Stellaria media*. Tender stems, leaves, tiny white star flowers, eaten raw. Mild, like corn silk. ID check that matters: **a single line of fine hairs running up one side of the stem** (it switches sides at each node), opposite leaves. Cool weather, gardens and lawns, spring through fall.

Lamb's quarters -- *Chenopodium album*. "Wild spinach," and it means it -- cook it 1:1 like spinach. Young leaves fine raw in small amounts; cook full servings (oxalic acid -- blanching leaches most of it out). ID: diamond/goosefoot-shaped leaves with a **whitish powdery coating underneath**, especially on young growth. Gardens, compost, disturbed soil, spring through fall.

Purslane -- *Portulaca oleracea*. Succulent, lemony, good raw in real quantity, high in omega-3s. Summer, garden beds and sidewalk cracks. The one check: **break a stem -- if white milky sap comes out, it's spurge, not purslane. Don't eat it.** Purslane stems are clean and succulent, leaves thick.

Wood sorrel -- *Oxalis* spp. Clover-like **heart-shaped leaflets in threes** that fold up at night -- unmistakable. Bright lemony nibble, raw. Moderation: a sprig or two while grazing, never a meal (oxalic acid). Lawns, woods, shady spots, spring through fall.

Violets -- *Viola* spp. Flowers and young leaves of blue/purple/white violets, raw or cooked, mild. Spring flowers, leaves into summer. Lawns and woods edges. Two cautions: eat yellow-flowered violets only in small amounts -- they can act as a laxative. And watch for lesser celandine -- shiny heart-shaped leaves, yellow buttercup flowers in early spring, toxic; when in doubt, wait for the violet's own five-petaled flowers before picking leaves. Never eat violet roots or rhizomes. (African violets are an unrelated houseplant -- not this.)

Plantain -- *Plantago major*. The weed, not the banana. Basal rosette of oval ribbed leaves; **3-7 parallel veins** -- chew one and the fibers pull out like threads. Young leaves raw or cooked; older ones get stringy, so cook them longer. Lawns, paths, compacted soil.

Garlic mustard -- *Alliaria petiolata*. Young spring leaves, raw or cooked; roots grated like horseradish. The ID confirmation: **crush a leaf -- it must smell distinctly of garlic.** No garlic-smelling plant in the region is toxic. Aggressive invasive, so harvest it hard and feel good about it.

Blackberry -- *Rubus* spp. Ripe black berries, mid-to-late summer, field edges and clearings. Only pick berries that are fully black, plump, and release easily. The aggregate-berry structure of true *Rubus* berries (blackberry/raspberry/dewberry) has **no toxic lookalike in North America.** One of the safest things you can put in your mouth out here.

Cattail -- *Typha latifolia*. "The supermarket of the swamp." Spring: young shoots, peeled to the tender white core, asparagus-like. Early summer: immature green flower spikes, boiled like corn. Summer:

clouds of yellow pollen shaken into flour. Fall/winter: starchy rhizomes, boiled or dried and ground. Pond margins and ditches -- **harvest only from clean water**, because cattails absorb whatever's in it. The one check: make sure it's cattail and not yellow flag iris -- iris leaves are **flat with a raised center vein** and fan from the base; cattail leaves are flat ribbons, spongy and D-shaped in cross-section. Confirm by last year's brown "hot dog" spikes standing nearby.

3. Worth learning next (real food, real rules)

These feed you better, but every one of them comes with a rule you learn cold *before* the first bite.

Ramps (wild leek) -- *Allium tricoccum*. Early spring, rich moist woods, often in huge colonies. Leaves like spinach, bulbs like garlic. The rule: **crush a leaf of each plant you pick -- it must smell like onion**. Lily of the valley grows in the same woods, looks similar, and will stop your heart (cardiac glycosides). Lily of the valley never smells like onion. Smell can rub off onto your hands or a mixed bunch, so one sniff of the pile is not enough -- crush and smell every single plant, and use the smell *plus* leaf, bulb, and habitat traits. Never the smell alone. Harvest kindly: one leaf per plant, under a tenth of the patch. Bulbs only where they're abundant -- and know that even leaving the root crown, regrowth is slow and uncertain. Leaves-only is the sustainable default.

Stinging nettle -- *Urtica dioica*. Spring shoots, top 4-6 inches, while plants are under knee height -- **stop once they flower** (older leaves get gritty). Stream banks and floodplains. The rule: **never eat it raw**. Blanching 1-2 minutes destroys the sting completely; then it's just spinach. Gloves and sleeves for harvest. Square stem, opposite toothed leaves, visible bristles.

Acorns -- *Quercus* spp. Fall. The rule: **raw acorns are bitter and hard on your gut -- you leach the tannins first**. Float-test (toss floaters), shell, grind to coarse meal. White oak group (rounded leaf lobes) = low tannin, easy. Red oak group (pointy lobes) = high tannin, long leach. Cold-leach: cover meal with cold water, refrigerate, pour off the brown water daily until a nibble tastes bland and nutty, not mouth-puckering -- the water may still look tea-colored; go by taste, not clarity. Days to two weeks. Hot-leach (faster): cover with *already-boiling* water, steep, drain, repeat with fresh *boiling* water -- start every round with already-boiling water, that's the traditional hot-leach method. Done when a nibble tastes nutty and bland, not mouth-puckering.

Hickory nuts -- *Carya* spp., shagbark (*C. ovata*) best. Fall, when husks split in four. Gather fast (squirrels), dry, float-test, crack with a

hammer. The finest wild nut in the East. Skip bitternut hickory (*C. cordiformis*) -- bitter, inedible; learn shagbark's peeling bark.

Black walnuts -- *Juglans nigra*. Fall. Wear gloves -- the husks stain everything permanently. Husk promptly, float-test, **cure 2-3 weeks** in a cool dry ventilated spot, crack with a hammer (regular nutcrackers will die trying). Freeze the nutmeats or they go rancid. Strong flavor -- a little goes far.

Elderberry -- *Sambucus canadensis*. Late summer-fall, deep purple-black clusters in moist thickets. The rule: **never eat them raw**. Leaves, stems, bark, and seeds carry cyanide compounds; strip every stem, cook thoroughly (jam, syrup, pie) -- sustained heat breaks down most of the cyanide compounds. If it tastes bitter or off, don't eat it; raw or undercooked elderberries cause vomiting. Skip the red-berried elder entirely (*S. racemosa*) -- the one beginners should skip.

Burdock root -- *Arctium* spp. Fall through winter, **first-year roots only** -- big floppy leaf rosette with *no flower stalk*. Second year it bolts purple and the root turns to wood. Peel, slice, cook like carrots. Field edges, trailsides.

Mushrooms -- the serious talk. The edibility test doesn't work on fungi, "pretty sure" has killed experts, and some killers take days to show it. Rules: **100% certain or you don't eat it. Cook all wild mushrooms, no exceptions. Eat a small portion of any new species and wait 24 hours** -- and know that waiting doesn't protect against delayed-onset killers like amatoxins, which is exactly why "100% certain" comes first. Take a spore print** (cap on paper, 6-12 hours -- color is a key ID feature). Join a local mycological club before you trust your own eyes.

Three beginner-friendly ones for the region: **chicken of the woods** (*Laetiporus* spp.) -- bright orange-yellow shelf brackets on hardwood trunks, yellow pore surface, no gills; only eat tender young edges; avoid specimens on conifers or yew -- the conifer-loving species (*L. huroniensis* in the Northeast) is linked to more bad reactions, and it's nearly identical to the safe one. The reason isn't fully nailed down, so don't gamble on the mechanism. **Hen of the woods / maitake** (*Grifola frondosa*) -- gray-brown ruffled rosette at the base of oaks in fall; its lookalikes are merely inedible, not dangerous. **Morels** (*Morchella* spp.) -- spring, near dying elm and ash; **slice every single one lengthwise -- a true morel is completely hollow, one continuous chamber**. False morels are chambered or cottony inside and toxic *even cooked*. Never eat morels raw.

Pokeweed -- *Phytolacca americana*. Included with maximum

respect, because it's the classic Appalachian spring green -- and because it has *killed people*. Read this whole entry before you even think about touching it.

The whole plant carries toxins (phytolaccatoxin and related compounds), and the dose climbs as the plant grows. The root is the most poisonous part -- never eat it, never chew it, never use it as a "wild vegetable" the way some old-timers used it as a purgative. Mature stems, mature leaves, and berries are poisonous. The berries look like food -- dark purple clusters, almost like wild grapes -- and children have died eating them.

Pokeweed poisoning is not a stomach ache. It hits hard and fast: violent vomiting, bloody diarrhea, severe cramping, then weakness, difficulty breathing, convulsions, and in bad cases death. People have died from eating the root, from eating mature leaves, from drinking tea made from the plant, and from eating shoots that weren't prepared right.

If you are going to eat it anyway -- the traditional method, and only this method: young shoots **under 8 inches, completely green, zero purple anywhere** (purple in the stem means the toxins are climbing -- walk away). Boil in **three changes of water, no exceptions:** shoots into *already-boiling* water, boil, drain and discard the water, repeat twice more, then cook through. This is not a suggestion. The boiling leaches the toxins out; skipping a change means eating them.

Even done right, this is the one plant in this book where strong authorities say a beginner should skip it entirely. I won't argue with them. If that paragraph made you nervous -- good. Learn it from a person who grew up eating it, not from a book, or skip it. There are nine other plants in Section 2, and none of them can kill you.

Wild carrot -- honestly? Skip it. The root is a thin carrot and the lookalike is **poison hemlock**, which is lethal. The ID is real (hemlock: smooth hollow stem, often -- not always -- purple-blotched, usually much taller; wild carrot: hairy solid green stem, shorter), but the stakes-per-calorie math is terrible. Plenty of foragers never touch it. Be one of them until an expert teaches you in person.



4. The killers -- memorize on sight

Learn these the way you'd learn the face of someone who means you harm. If a plant you're considering looks *anything* like one of these, walk away.

Poison hemlock -- *Conium maculatum*. 6-10 feet tall. **Smooth, hairless stems with purple blotches.** Lacy fern-like leaves, white umbrella flowers. Every part deadly. Ditches, roadsides, moist disturbed ground.

Water hemlock -- *Cicuta maculata*. Wet ground only -- marshes, ditches, stream banks. White umbrella flowers, purple-streaked hollow stems. Cut the root lengthwise and it shows **distinct**

horizontal chambers -- no other carrot-family plant has this. Called the most violently poisonous plant in North America: seizures within an hour, a few bites of root can kill.

Foxglove -- *Digitalis purpurea*. Tall spike of purple-pink **tubular bell flowers** with spotted throats; soft hairy oval leaves. Cardiac glycosides -- it slows and stops the heart. Woodland edges, gardens gone wild.

Lily of the valley -- *Convallaria majalis*. Low groundcover, pairs of broad oval leaves, strings of small white **hanging bells**, red berries in fall. Same heart-stopping chemistry as foxglove. Old homesteads, shady woods -- exactly where ramps grow. **Crush and smell every plant: onion smell plus the right leaves, or you don't eat it. No smell, no eat.**

White snakeroot -- *Ageratina altissima*. 1-3 feet, opposite heart-shaped toothed leaves, flat-topped clusters of small **fuzzy white flowers** with no petals, late summer-fall. Contains tremetol -- the "milk sickness" plant that killed Abraham Lincoln's mother. Shady woods.

Mature pokeweed -- *Phytolacca americana*. 4-10 feet, thick **magenta-red stalks**, huge leaves, drooping clusters of dark purple berries. Root, stems, leaves, berries -- toxic. (Young shoots only, triple-boiled -- Section 3.)

5. The universal edibility test (last resort)

This is the U.S. Army's protocol (FM 21-76, carried forward in ATP 3-50.21) for testing an unknown plant when you're genuinely starving. It takes about 24 hours per plant part. If you're not starving, don't bother -- learn your plants instead.

Don't even start if the plant has: milky or discolored sap, bitter or soapy taste, almond scent in leaves or stems, spines or stinging hairs -- or **umbrella-shaped flower clusters** (the hemlock family; do not test, do not eat). Beans or seeds in pods are out too.

1. **Fast 8 hours** (water only), so any reaction is the plant's doing. 2. Test **one part at a time** -- leaves, stems, roots, buds separately. 3. Smell it. Strong, acid, or almond odors are bad signs. 4. Rub it on your inner wrist. Wait 15 minutes. Rash, burning, itching -- discard. 5. Prepare it the way you'd eat it (cook the test portion if you'd cook it). 6. Touch a pinch to your outer lip. Wait 3 minutes. Reaction -- discard. 7. Hold it on your tongue 15 minutes without chewing. Reaction -- discard. 8. Chew a small pinch thoroughly, hold 15 minutes, **don't swallow**. Reaction -- discard. 9. Swallow the small chewed portion. Wait **8 hours**, eating nothing else. Nausea, cramps, dizziness -- discard. 10. All clear? Eat a small meal-sized portion. Wait **8 more hours**. Still fine -- that part of that plant is *probably* safe in normal amounts. This test catches fast irritants and gut poisons. It cannot catch poisons that take days to hurt your liver or kidneys -- that's why it's the last resort, not a green light.

Slow? Yes. That's the price of not knowing. The fast version of this test is called poisoning.

Go learn for real

This book gets you oriented. It does not make you a forager. What makes you a forager:

1. **A real field guide with color photos.** Peterson's *Field Guide to Edible Wild Plants* -- used copies cost a few bucks. My drawings are art, not ID tools. Never forget that. 2. **A person.** One walk with someone who knows ramps from lily of the valley is worth a season of reading. Check local foraging groups, nature centers, mycological clubs. 3. **Your own backyard.** Learn the ten safe plants in Section 2 where you live, in daylight, with the book open. By the time you're cold and hungry in the woods, ID should be reflex, not research.

The woods are a pantry with no labels and a few poison bottles mixed in. Learn the labels. Respect the bottles. Eat well.

-- Rook